

African skimmer

Rynchops flavirostris

Although it looks “broken” at first glance, the African skimmer’s bill is a specialized tool, used for fishing at the surface of calm water. Fine, parallel grooves on each side reduce friction, so that the bird can fly with the elongated tip of the lower mandible dipped in the water without tipping forward. Skimmers nest on remote, exposed sandbanks, often in temperatures above 95°F (35°C).

- ↔ 14–17 in (36–43 cm)
- ⚖ 4–7 oz (100–200 g)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🐟 Fish
- 🏠  Sub-Saharan Africa

▽ SNATCHING FISH

When the African skimmer’s lower mandible touches a fish, it triggers a reflex mechanism to snatch the prey.



Leopard tortoise

Stigmochelys pardalis

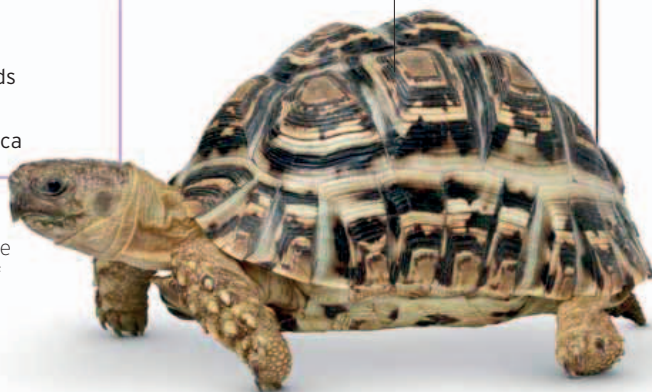
This large tortoise prefers drier habitats, where it eats grassy plants, herbs, flowers, seeds, and berries. Males compete for females by butting one another until one is overturned. The female lays up to six clutches of between five and 25 eggs in a season, burying each clutch in a burrow. The eggs hatch after about nine to 14 months, depending on temperature, rainfall, and location, and the young mature in five to six years. The maximum lifespan of the leopard tortoise is more than 100 years.

- ↔ 12–28 in (30–71 cm)
- ⚖ 44 lb (20 kg)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🌿 Grasses, fruit, seeds
- 🏠  E. to Southern Africa

high-domed shell with raised scutes

▷ HIGHLY PATTERNED

The scutes of the shell have rosettes similar to those of a leopard: straw yellow or tan-brown with black.



Nile monitor

Varanus niloticus

Fiercely defiant, the powerful Nile monitor readily defends its meal against crocodiles and big cats. Food can be almost any meat from insects, snails, and crabs to fish, amphibians, turtles, snakes, small mammals, and bird and reptile eggs as well as carrion. This huge lizard—the largest in Africa—stalks prey quietly and then strikes in a flash. It bites hard with its peglike teeth set in crushing jaws, writhes its muscular body, whips its long tail, and slashes violently with its sharp-clawed feet.

Generally found in or near slow-moving rivers and lakes, the semiaquatic Nile monitor can swim as fast and expertly as it runs and climbs. They bask in the sun on exposed sections of a bank or on nearby rocks or tree stumps. In cooler parts of their range, Nile monitors hibernate in communal dens.

Sealed in for safety

After the August–September rains, male Nile monitors wrestle and grapple for the right to mate. The female digs a hole in a damp termite mound and lays up to 60 eggs—the largest number of any lizard in a single clutch. The termites repair the mound, sealing in the eggs so they incubate in stable conditions. The eggs hatch in six to nine months, but the hatchlings, which are about 12 in (30 cm) long, remain in the nest until fresh rains soften the soil enough for them to dig their way out.

A **threatened** Nile monitor will **squirt fetid material** from its **cloaca**

